

Positionality Reflection: Identity and Pedagogical Outlook

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In education, the interplay of identity and learning strategies deeply influences metacognitive processes (Crenshaw, 1989; hooks, 1994; Freire, 1970). Personal narratives, like my own, forged from a working-class background, rural upbringing, and distinct gender identity, hold a transformative potential that significantly shapes academic interactions. As the first college graduate on both sides of my extended family, born into a very working-class environment, I bring a unique perspective to my pedagogical practice. My upbringing, devoid of access to advanced classes and rooted in a conservative household, has instilled in me both resilience and an acute awareness of educational inequities. These experiences have shaped how I approach my work as an educator, infusing it with empathy and a commitment to advocating for students from similar backgrounds.

Growing up without access to advanced classes made me acutely aware of the disparities in educational opportunities. It drives me to advocate for all students, particularly those from marginalized backgrounds, ensuring they have access to the resources and support they need to succeed. My working-class background has instilled in me a sense of empathy and understanding for students facing similar challenges. It motivates me to create a supportive and inclusive learning environment where all students feel valued and empowered. Additionally, my rural upbringing has fostered in me a deep appreciation for hands-on learning experiences and a connection to nature, which I integrate into my teaching practices to engage students with diverse learning styles.

Being raised in a conservative household and later grappling with the privilege of being white has been a journey of self-reflection and growth. As a teacher working with marginalized students, I've had to confront my own biases and work through my savior complex. Understanding the impact of my privilege has been a humbling experience, driving me to continuously educate myself and strive for equity in my teaching practices. It has taught me the importance of centering the voices and experiences of marginalized communities, amplifying their perspectives in the classroom, and advocating for systemic change within educational institutions. Furthermore, my experiences navigating conservative ideologies have equipped me with the ability to engage in difficult conversations with students and colleagues, fostering a classroom environment where diverse perspectives are respected and valued.

Furthermore, structural challenges within educational systems disproportionately burden marginalized learners, dictating opportunities based on power dynamics and privilege (Crenshaw, 1989; Paris, 2012). Affluent students often access high-quality educational resources, private tutors, and extracurricular activities, enhancing their academic development. Conversely, marginalized students may attend underfunded schools with limited resources, face language barriers, or lack access to stable housing, hindering their educational progress. These disparities not only affect academic achievement but also shape students' self-perception, aspirations, and sense of belonging within educational spaces. Recognizing and urgently addressing these systemic inequities is essential for creating an inclusive learning environment where all students can thrive. As someone who has experienced firsthand the impact of such disparities, I am deeply committed to dismantling these structural barriers and advocating for equitable educational opportunities for all students.

My pedagogical outlook has undergone a profound transformation through the lens

of intersectionality and critical pedagogy, reshaping my understanding of how educational systems perpetuate inequality and marginalization. Intersectionality, as conceptualized by Kimberlé Crenshaw (1989), illuminates the interconnectedness of social identities and the complex ways in which power operates within educational contexts. It underscores the importance of recognizing and addressing the intersecting forms of oppression that shape students' experiences, particularly those from marginalized communities. This framework has challenged me to critically examine the ways in which educational practices, including curriculum development and instructional methodologies, may inadvertently reinforce systems of privilege and exclusion. As someone who has navigated intersecting identities, including gender, socioeconomic status, and race, I am committed to creating educational spaces that honor and validate the lived experiences of all students.

Delving deeper into the historical context of education, I've come to realize the role of advanced academic programs in perpetuating inequality. These programs, initially designed as havens for white students to evade integration efforts in public schools, have evolved into bastions of privilege and gateways to elite institutions (Oakes, 1985). The criteria for admission often reflect cultural biases and favor students from affluent backgrounds, further entrenching disparities along racial, socioeconomic, and gender lines (Oakes, 1985; Ladson-Billings, 2006). As an educator committed to equity and social justice, this realization has prompted me to critically interrogate the structures and practices within advanced academic programs and advocate for reforms that promote access and inclusivity for all students. Drawing from my own experiences of navigating educational barriers, I am dedicated to challenging these inequities and advocating for policies that ensure equitable access to educational opportunities for all students, regardless of their background or identity.

Critical pedagogy, inspired by the works of Paulo Freire (1970) and bell hooks (1994), has been instrumental in guiding my pedagogical praxis. Freire's notion of conscientização, or critical consciousness, highlights the transformative potential of education in fostering critical awareness and social action. By encouraging students to critically analyze and challenge oppressive structures, critical pedagogy empowers them to become agents of change in their communities. Similarly, hooks' emphasis on education as a practice of freedom underscores the liberatory potential of education in challenging hegemonic narratives and fostering inclusive learning environments. These insights have deepened my commitment to creating educational spaces that prioritize equity, justice, and liberation for all students. As an educator who has grappled with the complexities of privilege and power dynamics, I am committed to facilitating critical dialogue and empowering students to critically engage with the world around them.

Culturally sustaining pedagogy, as articulated by Django Paris (2012), offers a framework for designing educational experiences that honor and affirm diverse cultural backgrounds and experiences. This approach challenges the notion of a singular, dominant culture in education and advocates for the integration of culturally relevant content and teaching practices into the curriculum. By centering the voices and experiences of marginalized communities, culturally sustaining pedagogy promotes a sense of belonging and empowerment among students. As an educator, I strive to incorporate culturally sustaining pedagogy principles into my practice, ensuring all students feel valued, represented, and engaged in their learning journey. This commitment extends beyond simply integrating diverse content; it involves actively engaging with students' cultural backgrounds, languages, and experiences to create a learning environment that fosters their identity development and success.

In my journey as an educator, these insights have fueled my commitment to reimagining curriculum development and instructional practices through an intersectional and culturally sustaining lens. I recognize the importance of critically evaluating existing educational structures, challenging biases, and amplifying marginalized voices in the educational discourse. By embracing

intersectionality, critical pedagogy, and culturally sustaining pedagogy, educators can work towards creating transformative educational experiences that empower students to engage with the world and enact positive change critically.

References

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